

Neonatal intensive care babies

Around 10 to 15 percent of all babies born in the US need to spend time in a neonatal intensive care unit (NICU). Babies most often need extra care to assist them with breathing until their lungs have matured.

There are many reasons why your baby may need special care, the most common one being prematurity (being born before 37 weeks). Babies may need to spend days, weeks, or sometimes months in a NICU until they are big enough and well enough to go home.

Neonatal intensive care unit

If your baby is in a NICU, this is a particularly stressful time. It helps to understand a bit about who will be caring for your baby, what they will be doing, and how to make sure you're fully informed at all times.

In the US, most hospitals have a unit to provide special nursing and medical care for babies; these are divided into three levels depending on the degree of care offered. Level one is the most basic level. These units don't provide long-term ventilatory support, but they are expert at caring for babies who are slightly premature, need frequent nursing, or have previously been ventilated and are ready to be transferred to less intensive care. Level-two units ventilate and give intensive care to babies from 26 weeks' gestation. Level-three units offer intensive care for babies born as early as 23 weeks, and can often do neonatal surgery.

All these units are staffed by special nurses and doctors who will be happy to show you around before the baby is born if there is time.

Ward rounds Most units have rounds each morning, and the more intensive units will have another round later in the day. Some allow parents to be present and to ask questions, while others prefer parents to wait outside and then make time to talk to them afterward.

Communication and visiting You may be able to spend some time with your baby before they are sent to a NICU. However, if your baby needs to be on a ventilator, or has another serious problem, they will be sent immediately to neonatal intensive care, and you may not have any time together after the birth. You'll be encouraged to see your baby as soon as they have been transferred, and if you're unable to go immediately, you may be given a photo of your baby.

You should be able to see your baby any time of the day or night and the nurses will be happy to update you regularly. The doctors will also give you an update on an ad hoc basis or arrange to meet you for a more formal chat. Other family members may be able to visit the unit with your permission.